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IN THE MAKING

A legacy of activism inspires climate protests at The Game

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BREAKING GROUND

Sidewalk Labs proposes a new future for cities

BY **PAUL ROTMAN**

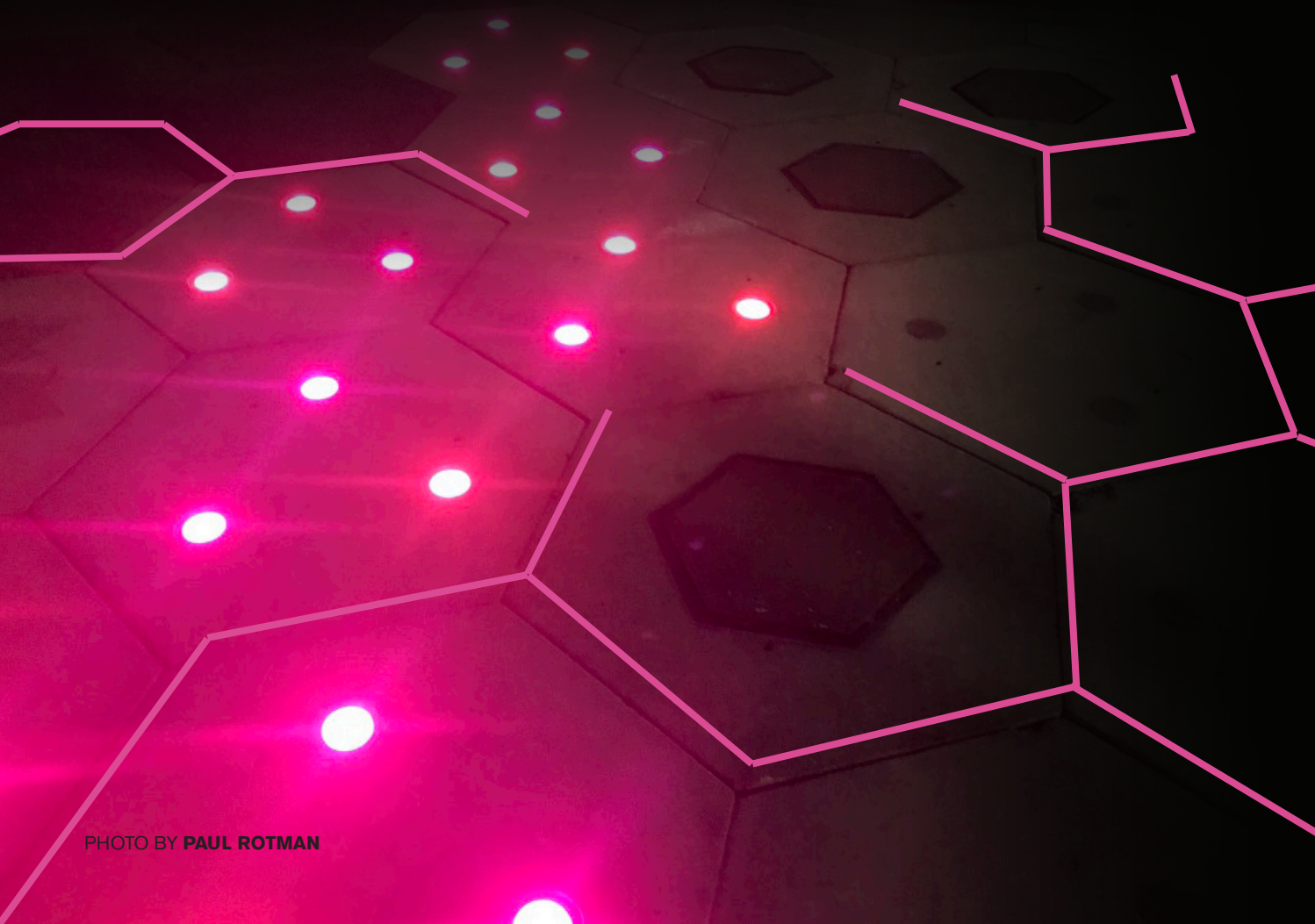


PHOTO BY **PAUL ROTMAN**

IT'S OCTOBER 2017, and Eric Schmidt is standing in front of a crowd of reporters in downtown Toronto. He is still the chairman of Alphabet, the oft-forgotten behemoth parent of Google. A few months from now, he will step down and take a role as chairman of the U.S. Department of Defense's Defense Innovation Advisory Board. Already, though, Schmidt is curious about what it would be like to use his enormous private influence in the governmental sphere.

Schmidt is comfortable with the press. "[Canadian Prime Minister Justin Trudeau] invited me to come chat," he shares, speaking casually of a meeting two years prior. Trudeau, Schmidt recounts, said: "We want Canada to be Silicon Valley plus everything else Canada is."

For Schmidt, Trudeau's pitch seemed different from the ambitious statements politicians often make. "Somehow I believed him, I think because of his socks," he jokes, referring to the Prime Minister's fondness for sporting vibrant socks at formal events.

The high-profile event—with a guest list including Trudeau himself, former Ontario Premier Kathleen Wynne, Toronto Mayor John Tory, and distinguished Toronto real estate developers—marks the official appointment of Sidewalk Labs, an Alphabet subsidiary, as the Innovation and Funding Partner to develop a small but extremely valuable plot of land on Toronto's eastern waterfront.

Although at the time it is unclear exactly what the project would look like, a flurry of activity in the following months—led by a team of experts in private equity, technology, and urban design—will culminate in a proposal for a high-tech neighborhood unlike anything North America has ever seen.

Just over two years later, the blueprints will be ready, public support will be mostly mobilized, and Sidewalk's team will be sitting on their hands, waiting for final government approval before they can break ground.

TRUDEAU'S VISION of turning Canada into an innovation hub was at first the job of a tri-government agency called Waterfront Toronto. Since its inception in 2001, and with the help of collective efforts from the municipal, provincial, and federal governments, Waterfront Toronto has worked to revitalize over 2,000 acres of brownfield site on the shores of Lake Ontario.

Wanting to tackle a more ambitious project, the agency issued a request for proposals (RFP) in April 2017. They were searching for a partner, one with "invention ingrained in its culture" that would "lead the world" in building cities with revamped business and climate-positive practices.

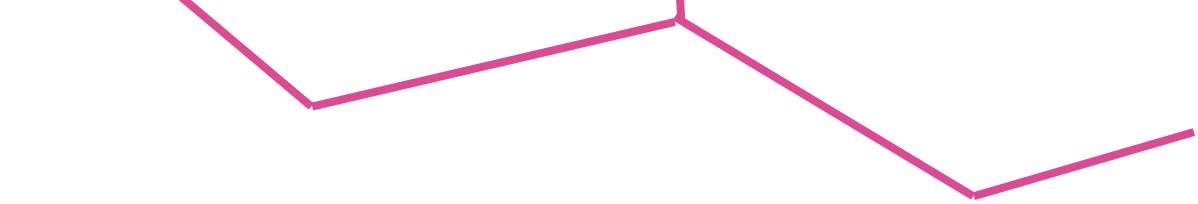
Mazyar Mortazavi, a member of Waterfront Toronto's Board of Directors, shared his logic with *The Politic*: "The public and private sector[s] need to be collaborating and working together because the traditional model of publicly funded solutions are...just not the way that they used to be."

The focus of Waterfront Toronto's RFP, a 12-acre area called Quayside, is different from what you'd expect to find just outside of a large city. Established in the early 1920s as an industrial hub, Quayside—sparsely populated and devoid of shops and high-rise buildings—is instead characterized by its sprawling parking lots and aging industrial-era warehouses. Sidewalk describes it in their plan as the "largest underdeveloped parcel of urban land in North America."

Sidewalk Labs jumped at the opportunity, launching a $1.4 billion planned development project in Quayside, the first of its kind. They proposed transforming everything—from crosswalks to building materials to weather-adaptive canopies for buildings. Despite oversight by a tri-government agency and the solicitation of feedback from tens of thousands of Torontonians, however, many remain wary of welcoming a foreign big tech firm with open arms and asking them to build a community.

SIDEWALK'S VISION captivated Waterfront Toronto. "The[ir] proposal tr[ied] to push the envelope on how urban development could be done," Mortazavi recalled of Sidewalk's plans.

The scope of their proposed innovations is vast. One technology that Sidewalk Labs is eager to showcase—"Dynamic Street," a collaboration with MIT's Senseable City Lab—proposes that a series of adjoined concrete, hexagonal tiles will eventually render curbs and street lines obsolete. Each tile—equipped with sensors, heating coils to melt snow, and an LED light—could transform an urban space from a road to a bike path, sidewalk, or plaza in a matter of minutes.



While working in New York, Joe Berridge, now a partner at Toronto-based city planning firm Urban Strategies, moved in the same professional circles as Dan Doctoroff, then Deputy Mayor for Economic Development and Rebuilding for former Mayor Michael Bloomberg.

"Quite frankly, [Doctoroff, now Sidewalk's CEO] was the most impressive city-builder I've ever had anything to do with," Berridge shared with *The Politic*. From his experience working alongside the current Sidewalk boss, Berridge

planning and developing and running municipal infrastructure," said JJ Fueser GSAS '98 & '02 in an interview with *The Politic*. As a member of #BlockSidewalk, a sizable movement against the Quayside plan, she is concerned about potential data and privacy issues. For example, residents could access services like subsidized housing only after registering for what Sidewalk calls Distributed Digital Identity Credentials. An innovation only vaguely touched on in the Sidewalk plans, the DDICs would allow "the company [to] monitor, in

"THEY PROPOSED TRANS FROM CROSSWALKS TO I WEATHER-ADAPTIVE CAN

came to know Doctoroff as "just an incredible character, like a polymath driver guy, and when I heard he was coming to town with Sidewalk, on a personal level, I was ecstatic."

Berridge, whose firm consulted with Sidewalk Labs in developing their Master Innovation and Development Plan (MIDP), sees an opportunity for Toronto to position itself as a leader in innovative city building practices, right down to the wood frame construction. "The limits of wood are being pushed impressively," Berridge explained. "The production process is much lighter and much more energy-efficient."

Berridge believes that the 1,524 page MIDP—which boldly proposes a 190-acre development project, expanding far beyond the 12-acre Quayside area for which they originally applied—encompasses both conventional and unconventional approaches to city building. "There's a wonderful blend of the conventional street-grid city and the public-space city being the base on top of which something more imaginative and innovative is being built," he said.

Its 18 services and systems along with subsequent 52 subsystems—many of which have been tried elsewhere—nonetheless face wide-ranging criticism. The Dynamic Street, for instance, will have its fair share of roadblocks. "Customization...will probably create inefficiencies...which involves extra costs and training," Berridge explained. Further, "there could be liability issues too...when someone blames the new street design for creating an accident, as any lawyer will do."

NOT EVERYONE SHARES Berridge's confidence in Sidewalk.

"It's not a good idea to give a corporation, and particularly a corporation with monopoly power, such latitude in

real time, whether your income exceeded thresholds for social supports," Fueser explains.

But Fueser's uneasiness persisted. "There are a lot of concerns about gentrification, too," she continued. To capitalize on Toronto's booming tech sector, Google Canada pledged to move its headquarters to a currently undeveloped site adjacent to Quayside. In doing so, she cautioned, "All the housing that would be built would potentially go to the [high-income] workers that [Google] brought with them." Innovations like Sidewalk's self-driving trash bins, for example, can destroy public sector jobs. Sidewalk's reports, however, project that their proposal will create 93,000 jobs by 2040 and promise to promote subsidized housing. The company has declined requests for comment.

When Fueser attended one of Waterfront Toronto's public consultation meetings in November 2019, she quickly realized that she was not the only skeptic. The briefing began "in this sort of celebratory moment where I think Waterfront Toronto was proud that they stood up to tech giants" on some requests, Fueser recalled. But people were still uncomfortable. "It was an extremely hostile and tired environment, if I could describe it that way," she said with a laugh.

During the meeting, a sticky note caught Fueser's eye: "Google has just been accused of violating healthcare laws in the U.S. Shouldn't that be enough to cancel this project?" After reading it, she said, "It felt like something in the room just snapped."

The note referenced a federal investigation launched in November into Google's "Project Nightingale," an effort to collect health data on millions of Americans. This investiga-

tion is merely the latest episode of what has been built up to be a murky track record of the ethical practices behind Google's handling of user data. Only two months earlier, Google was forced to cough up $170 million to the FTC for selling YouTube ads targeted specifically at children.

With Sidewalk pitching in $50 million out of its own pocket to fund the development, Fueser could not help but question the Alphabet subsidiary's larger intentions with the personal data it collects. And in the age of Cambridge Analytica, these revelations have Torontonians on edge. "I think that the privacy issues are completely valid," Mortazavi affirmed. The responsibility, he believes, falls "on governments to set the policy frameworks within which Sidewalk Labs needs to operate.

IN RESPONSE to the concerns, Sidewalk was forced to elaborate on their plans. They stated that their goals are rather simple: First, they want to demonstrate how their innovations will change urban quality of life. Second, they want a "reasonable return" on their $50 million investment.

Sidewalk affirms that all personal data will be stored within Canada's borders; they will not sell or share personal information to companies—including Google—without explicit consent, and they will not use it for targeted advertising. In addition, they emphasized the absence of all facial recognition technology from their plans.

The company had also responded to mounting criticism from the real estate community when in February 2019, Doctoroff wrote in the *Toronto Star* that Sidewalk would no longer pursue the role of "lead developer" on the Quayside project. Instead of tackling all 190 acres outlined in the MIDP, he wrote, the company would mainly focus on the 12 acres of Quayside before stepping back to a role as an adviser and investor on future development projects.

Though a powerful public outcry ultimately forced Sidewalk to scale back, Berridge is convinced that Doctoroff will keep the public in Sidewalk's favor. "To be candid: they managed public opinion [and didn't just take criticism] randomly," he said. "They were very sophisticated in that."

Indeed, a May 2019 poll found that 54 percent of Torontonians support the project after its adjustments and 29 percent are undecided. Mortazavi, for one, trusts that Sidewalk understands that Quayside can't "be solely their project," and instead that "they need to act as a partner" with local residents.

AMID THE crumbling sheds and wired fences that line the Quayside shores, one building stands out: a royal blue warehouse, surrounded by bright yellow picnic tables, a futuristic weather canopy, and some illuminated Dynamic Street tiles in its parking lot. Named "307" for its address on Lakeshore Boulevard East, the building houses more than just Sidewalk's headquarters. Each Sunday, Sidewalk holds public "open hours" to give Torontonians a glimpse of the future that Sidewalk envisions for them.

FORMING EVERYTHING— BUILDING MATERIALS TO OPIES FOR BUILDINGS."



Proposed neighborhood

Doctoroff's compromise of "stepping back" could, in Berridge's view, prevent Sidewalk from turning some of its boldest visions showcased at 307 into realities. "City planning is not architecture; city planning is done at scale," Berridge said of the circumscribed neighborhood. "If you want to have a private carless neighborhood, which is an opportunity sitting there waiting for us…It makes no sense on a 13-acre site."

Fueser, though happy with the scale-back, was also dissatisfied with Doctoroff's decision, given that it fell short of the project's complete cancellation. "I think [Sidewalk's got] a foot in the door," she said. "It's just going to take a little longer and it will take more work for them to get there."

Two years and thousands of pages of documents later, whether Sidewalk will "get there"—and where exactly they are trying "to get"—is not perfectly clear. For starters, Sidewalk's objectives have taken a nearly 180-degree turn over the last three years. A company that was once defined by Schmidt's 2017 remarks asking for governments to "give us a city and put us in charge" has now evolved into a project in collaboration with the surrounding community.



Sidewalk's Quayside office

With a tri-government organization and local urban planning firm holding the reins, Mortazavi anticipates that the biggest innovation that will come of this experiment—beyond Sidewalk's technological proposals—will be showing the world what a strong partnership between the public and private sectors looks like. "It's a question of how do you actually develop frameworks to help mitigate that risk and ensure you're not taking everything on a wholesale and not actually considering what the downsides are," he said.

At the end of October 2019, Waterfront Toronto's Board unanimously voted to move the project forward into its formal evaluation phase, a point that Fueser and #BlockSidewalk hoped would never come.

"It's more like passing through a gate as opposed to getting to the finish line," Mortazavi said of the vote. "It's a pretty fulsome process around wanting to evaluate [the] financial and the practical aspects of the solution," he said. The Board's evaluation will come in March of this year.

With a project like this, it's more about process than product. "At the end of the day," Berridge reflects, "you get innovation by crashing and bashing around and seeing where you get."

UNNATURAL DISASTER

Communities fight to keep power local—and pipelines out

BY **MATTHEW YOUKILIS**

SOME PEOPLE THOUGHT a plane had gone down. As black smoke rose above them and scorching flames shot into the air, community members in San Bruno, California, didn't know what else could have caused the destruction they saw before them.

Rico Medina remembers the blazing heat on that day, September 9, 2010, as resources arrived and people fled, fire still raging. In an interview with *The Politic,* Medina, now the city's mayor, recalls the realization: It was not a plane that had crashed but a natural gas pipeline that had exploded. It had been over an hour before someone figured this out and turned off the gas. By the time the firefighters controlled the damage, 38 homes were destroyed and 70 others damaged. Fifty-eight people were injured and eight had been killed.

In the months and years after the explosion, various investigations tried to determine who was culpable for the disaster. These investigations uncovered that Pacific Gas and Electric (PG&E), the energy company that owned the pipeline, failed to properly inspect or maintain their infrastructure. The California Public Utilities Commission, the agency meant to regulate PG&E, was also shown to have a "cozy" relationship with the company itself, resulting in extremely insufficient government oversight.

State Senator Jerry Hill, the State Assemblyman serving San Bruno at the time, has been a leader among the politicians working to prevent similar catastrophes. On the night of the explosion, he remembers being at an event in South San Francisco and seeing the San Bruno flames off in the distance.

He also remembers how community members' feelings changed as the truth about the explosion slowly came out. "At first it was sorrow and sadness.... Everyone thought accidents happen. It didn't take us long to find that it was not an accident. That this was basically a negligent act on the part of PG&E," Senator Hill said in an interview with *The Politic.* "We found that they had diverted and cut expenses of about a half a billion dollars from safety, from maintenance, from proper testing of equipment and infrastructure, which would have identified this problem with that pipe."

In January 2017, PG&E was convicted of six felony charges, receiving the maximum allowable sentence—itself a weak slap on the wrist—which included a three-million-dollar fine and 10,000 hours of community service. "We will remain forever committed to taking action to meet the high safety standards that our customers, and we, demand and expect," the company apologized.

"I DON'T WAN BACKYARD, AND I IN ANYBODY'S

But Senator Hill believes that the problem was not limited to PG&E. "The California Public Utilities Commission, in my opinion, [was] a corrupt body," Senator Hill said. In fact, he cited CPUC's own report which detailed a wide berth given to private companies. Companies like PG&E "called a lot of the shots.... That's why they were allowed to get away with as much of the stuff as they did—because no one paid attention to them anyway."

OVER TWO THOUSAND MILES away, in a suburb outside Cincinnati, Ohio, Elizabeth Rueve-Miller is trying to keep the same tragedy from happening in her community. A member of NOPE (Neighbors Opposing Pipeline Extension) since early 2016, she has

spent years working to stop Duke Energy from building their Central Corridor Pipeline (CCP) through her home city.

Rueve-Miller hadn't known much about Duke—a top power holding company that serves millions of people across six states—when she heard of its plan in February 2016. "The more I researched the project, the more I found out that this wasn't like a pipeline that delivers gas to people's homes or a pipeline that delivers gas to neighborhoods," she said. "It was a massive transmission line designed to move tons of gas across distances. It's not like a normal pipeline that would be in a neighborhood. And once I learned that, I thought, 'I don't want this in my backyard, and I don't want this in anybody's backyard.'"

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S BACKYARD."

Duke doesn't see the problem. In an email interview with *The Politic*, Sally Thelen, a spokesperson, explained, "The Central Corridor Pipeline will help strengthen our local natural gas system and position Duke Energy Ohio to continue its long history of providing safe and reliable natural gas service to Ohio communities for decades to come."

But Rueve-Miller believed these arguments should not have been enough to gain approval from the Ohio Power Siting Board (OPSB), the branch of the Public Utilities Commission of Ohio that handles issues related to energy capacity and transmission. Over the phone, she carefully picked apart each one.

In establishing need, Duke has made three primary arguments. First, the new pipeline would allow them to retire propane peaking plants—which ensure customers have natural gas services on the coldest days of the year—that have been in service since 1964. If a plant's infrastructure is even slightly compromised, it would have to be shut down, which Thelen said "could be devastating" because thousands of homes and businesses could lose natural gas service.

Rueve-Miller's response: Duke did not show proper evidence of the need to retire the plants: "They didn't have any kind of...experts evaluate the propane peaking plants. They just said they needed to be replaced because [of how long] they've been in operation."

Second, Thelen argued that the new pipeline would allow Duke to replace older pipelines in their system while continuing to provide natural gas service.

Rueve-Miller's response: "Duke replaces pipelines all the time. They don't need this to replace existing pipelines, it just makes it easier for them."

Third, Thelen said that Duke "needs the flexibility to bring natural gas into southwest Ohio from a diverse supply of pipelines located north of our Ohio service territory."

And last, Reuve-Miller explained, "In their own testimony they said it's not a concern, not a problem, and this project does not address the North-South balance issues. There's very little impact on it."

Ultimately, it is the duty of the Ohio Power Siting Board to reconcile these diverging arguments, and on November 21, 2019, they approved the Central Corridor Pipeline with 41 corresponding stipulations, including higher safety standards. But NOPE still strongly believes the OPSB has failed Cincinnati, and is exploring potential next steps, including the possibility of

appealing to the Ohio Supreme Court.

In an interview with *The Politic,* Haynes Goddard, professor emeritus of economics at the University of Cincinnati and a NOPE member, shared, "It's pretty clear that the staff and the board—that's the OPSB—really ignored all the evidence. And safety is *totally* ignored."

This negligence leads Goddard to partly attribute what NOPE perceives as the OPSB's inefficacy to "regulatory capture," a political environment in which an oversight agency is beholden to the interests of a certain industry or ideological group. Periods of regulatory capture are cyclical, and Goddard believes we are in yet another era when the oversight agencies have little power.

EVEN AFTER THE EXPLOSION in San Bruno, emails released in July 2014 showed that the CPUC and PG&E were on more intimate terms. Executives commonly gathered for dinner meetings and, in one email, a PG&E member signed off, "Love you."

After the release of these emails, the CPUC released a bland statement arguing that it "takes seriously all allegations of bias and rule violations," and that it will work to "improv[e] safety in all of the industries the CPUC regulates."

Mayor Medina still maintains that PG&E and the CPUC failed his community: "There was deferred maintenance…. When you don't allocate the resources and maintain, that is a problem."

He added that the community knew too little of the pipeline's significance—or, in the case of many, even that it existed at all—and PG&E knew too much about the inner workings of the government. And he didn't just blame PG&E. He shared that, "Those at the top [in the CPUC] have to take the responsibility and the ownership."

Nevertheless, even as the truth has shown how preventable the tragedy was, Medina has been awestruck by the resilience of his community. "The courage of the residents and the support of the community were phenomenal. We had [so much] desire for helping and goodwill."

BACK IN OHIO, the public was invited on several occasions to speak about the pipeline at hearings scheduled by the OPSB. Rueve-Miller recalled, "There were hundreds of people there either testifying or listening to this testimony. There were some heartfelt, very personal stories, expressions of emotional anguish that occurred during that testimony, and nobody from the Ohio Power Siting Board could even bother to show up."

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Ignoring citizens, she explained, is dangerous: "It's easy to make a decision when you have distanced yourself from the reality of its impact."

Nonetheless, on November 21, 2019, the OPSB approved the pipeline on the grounds that Duke demonstrated "need to retire the aged and outdated propane air facilities" and to "improve the north/south system supply balance."

NOPE members are concerned about bias toward Duke Energy. In

particular, they cite large donations from Duke Energy lobbyists—including $7,250 from Charles Gerhardt III and $1,000 from James Benedict—to the 2018 campaign of Ohio Governor Mike DeWine, who appoints the leadership of the Public Utilities Commission of Ohio. In 2017, DeWine himself owned stock in Duke Energy, though it was not clear if this was still true in 2018.

These connections reinforce Goddard's regulatory capture thesis. Goddard explained that by the time a company like Duke is interested in building a pipeline, it's already too late. Underpaid, middle-tier engineers in the OPSB don't have an incentive to think twice repeating well-worn processes. "This has [already] been rubber-stamped," he said.

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WHILE CALIFORNIA may be starting to combat patterns of regulatory capture, weaker utility regulators still appear common elsewhere. A pipeline explosion in Massachusetts' Merrimack Valley in September 2018, which killed one person and injured over 20 more, led to major leadership changes at the Massachusetts Department of Public Utilities. An investigation later showed that Columbia Gas, the company the Massachusetts DPU was overseeing, improperly managed the pipeline's engineering. In August 2019, one person died in Danville, Kentucky in an explosion of a pipeline owned by the company Enbridge. In the aftermath, it became clear that the Kentucky Public Service Commission did not have the funding or personnel to inspect pipeline infrastructure as thoroughly as they hoped.

NOPE wants to make sure Cincinnati does not suffer a similar fate. Unlike San Bruno, where the community grew after the pipeline was already in place, the Cincinnati pipeline would be built in an already heavily populated area. "If there were to be an incident involving this particular pipeline, the result could be devastating with loss of human life, loss of property," Rueve-Miller said. That is why NOPE has worked so urgently to identify the problems within the system and try to combat them. On January 17, a judge presiding over the case put approval for Duke's pipeline on hold. In the meantime, NOPE plans to continue its advocacy as the OPSB consider whether they should re-hear the case.

San Bruno is giving them a model, now, for what to do differently. For starters, "We made sure the leadership of the Public Utilities Commission is now representative of the community and not the utilities, and is interested in safety as a priority," Senator Hill shared. Further, the CPUC has introduced more thorough training for new engineers and maintenance workers.

It shouldn't take a local tragedy to spur such changes, Senator Hill argued. Mayor Medina, reflecting on his city's experience, believes there is a path forward. He said, "You can overcome, you can move on, but you don't want to forget what got us here. Because at the same time maybe it could have been avoided."

CW: depression, suicide

Sexism and suicide in the K-pop industry

BY **ISABELLE RHEE**

HAIR DYED LIGHT PINK and dressed in a black romper, Sulli, an actress and former member of the hugely popular K-pop girl group f(x), stood on the center of the stage and began reading a string of malicious taunts directed at her. She was a host on the inaugural broadcast of the South Korean reality TV show *Night of Hate Comments*, where Korean celebrities gathered to tackle cy-

lens

berbullying by reading and discussing harsh comments left by netizens online.

Dubbed by her talent agency as the "visual," or the most attractive member of her group by Korean standards, Sulli stood before the cameras at five-foot-seven and an alleged 106 pounds. That year—2019—she had topped nearly all lists ranking the most beautiful women in K-pop. As she paged through her booklet of hate comments, she responded to each one with lighthearted laughter.

Four months later, she took her own life.

Commentators blame her suicide in part on persistent cyberbullying, especially targeted at her outspoken persona and feminist causes. After her death, *Night of Hate Comments* was discontinued.

successful export but one that carries a heavy price tag."

Within the past three months, two female idols in the K-pop industry—Sulli, and Goo Hara of the girl group Kara—have ended their own lives. Their causes of death were traced back to depression, misogynistic internet trolls, cyberbullying, and intimate partner violence. The loss of these women has spurred conversations around the world about the psychological distresses placed on idols, whose lives are scrutinized around the clock by netizens, as well as a larger culture of sexism and mental health stigma.

Pop culture is considered South Korea's most successful export, but one that carries a heavy price tag.

"A LOT OF ATTENTION has been placed on the fact that they were celebrities and were active in K-pop," Jenna Gibson, the Korea columnist for *The Diplomat*, shared with *The Politic*. "I understand that, but I think it's really important that we're talking about these greater issues that actually have very little to do with K-pop. It's really indicative of serious societal issues that Korea is struggling to deal with."

In particular, Gibson highlighted the social conservatism and misogyny woven deeply into the fabric of South Korea's patriarchal society. Sulli's progressive politics, of course, didn't always fit in. In a country that continues to outlaw abortion, she was shamed for supporting the right to choose. She was lambasted for being too "provocative" in a bra-less Instagram post. *On Night of Hate Comments,* Sulli reflected: "When I uploaded my photos without a bra, people talked about it a lot. I could have been scared. But I wasn't, because I thought it would be nice if more people could discard their prejudices."

During her time in the limelight, Hara—also the "visual" of her group—spoke out against cyberbullying, too. In early 2019, her manager released a statement admitting that Hara was battling depression, citing the legal battle between Hara and her ex-boyfriend—who secretly filmed her and threatened to post her sex videos online—as a major source of distress. It was painfully reminiscient of the Burning Sun Scandal, a major sex scandal in which numerous male celebrities assaulted, pimped, and secretly filmed women, that was uncovered the same year.

Hara's ex-boyfriend was eventually convicted of multiple crimes, including physical assault and blackmail. Yet, following Hara's decision in 2018 to file a lawsuit against her abuser, the internet blamed *her* for being too sexually promiscuous. In May 2019, she was hospitalized for an attempted suicide.

She took her life in November.

In the wake of mourning Hara and Sulli, South Korean organizers for women's justice have mobilized to combat online abuse and sexual harassment. In one of the countries most impacted by #MeToo, their message is clear: these women were killed by a society that ostracized and victimized them.

An online petition pressuring South Korean President Moon Jae In to enact longer and more severe punishments for sexual harassment perpetrators has collected over 260,000 signatures since Hara's death. Currently, politicians are drafting Sulli's Law, which would punish malicious online commenting. So far, the law, which would implement a "Real ID" policy requiring all netizens to put a face behind their comments, is in limbo, and similar ones have been struck down by South Korean courts due to concerns over free speech suppression. Yet, even discussing protections for these women is a concrete step towards ensuring that no more lives fall victim to vitriol and hate.

FOR MALE K-POP IDOLS, it's a different world. Men easily retain their fan bases after drug and gambling charges—something unheard of for women—while female idols receive scrutiny for dating, gaining weight, or showing too much skin. Sulli's and Hara's deaths add to a haunting statistic: nine out of the eleven most recent high-profile suicides in Korean entertainment were committed by women.

"[Sulli and Hara] were treated

"Pop culture" is South Korea's most consider

more than unfairly by the public. It's reflective of how K-pop idols are treated as public figures and are held to similar ethical standards as politicians," said Hyun Jo Kim '20, a student from Korea. "But in my opinion, they are not ethical standards. They are just unfair social norms," he continued.

"Idols are presented to the public in a way that is very akin to a service industry," explained CedarBough Saeji, Professor of Asian Languages and Cultures at Indiana University. "Because the viewer is constructed as being a heterosexual male...their entire job is to please men. Talking back, or even thinking, is not a requirement of their job." While the subordination of female entertainers and public figures is not an issue exclusive to Korea, Saeji argued that the cultural influence of mandatory military service for men in South Korea elevates this gender bifurcation in Korean society.

EVANGELINE PANG RECALLS the moment she became interested in K-pop. She began posting dance videos on her YouTube account and months later, talent agency DSP media—the same as Hara's—scouted her to join their client base.

"It started when I was around 13. I was bullied in school, and there was this talent show when each class was supposed to come up with a dance. I got excluded, and I needed to find a way to learn how to dance, and obviously K-pop involves a lot of choreography. So the first dance I learned how to dance to was a K-pop song," explained Pang. By the time DSP Media reached out to Pang inviting her to audition, however, she was hesitant. "I feel like K-pop gives off a very innocent facade, which is why I really wanted to investigate things that go on behind the scenes."

When stars would describe such "ridiculous diets as not eating for the entire day," Pang found it troubling that "Everyone on the show would be like, 'You're so dedicated!'" She then recited the long list of physical standards female stars are held to: "Long legs, white skin—there's a lot of colorism. Big eyes, a V-shaped chin, a small waist. They have standards for every single thing," she exclaimed. "People just focus on the looks."

These rigid beauty standards can be seen everywhere in Korea, from the streets of Seoul's Gangnam District—the city's "beauty belt," which houses hundreds of plastic surgery centers—to websites dedicated to interrogating which K-pop stars have undergone cosmetic surgeries with before-and-after photos. While female idols are pressured by the public and their companies to undergo plastic surgery, they also run the risk of being shamed for altering their appearances too much—a sign that they were too ugly to enter the industry in the first place. Last March, fans responded to a selfie Hara posted on Instagram by criticizing her most recent eyelid surgery, despite, ironically, eyelid surgery being so encouraged among South Korean women that many young women receive double eyelid surgery as a graduation gift.

"Especially for female stars, it's immediately about how they look," Gibson explained. "Are they wearing something that's too skimpy? Are they wearing something that's not skimpy enough? Do they look a little tired? It's insane, the level of scrutiny. A lot of female celebrities have talked about the amount of weight they lose."

In particular, Gibson remembered an August 2018 interview with Ailee, another popular K-pop idol-songwriter, on the show *Hidden Singer*. In the interview, Ailee shared stories of the extreme dieting she underwent to hit the below-50-kilogram (110-pound) idol standard, an expectation placed on female idols no matter their height. "When I was 49 kilograms, I looked great, but I think I was the most depressed. So I've decided to no longer worry about my weight and instead concentrate on my music and being happy."

Gibson continued, "That was a really positive interview. But I can guarantee you that she's probably gotten comments about it. It has to get to you. Even if you are trying to do your best and live

> "Men easily retain their fan bases after drug and gambling charges—something unheard of for women—while female idols receive scrutiny for dating, gaining weight, or showing too much skin."

your life, if you are seeing thousands upon thousands of comments, of course it gets to you."

"RIGHT NOW in Korean society, people are under pretty intense pressure," explained Saeji. "These parents believed all they had to do was get a good education to have a good life and have foisted this same idea onto their children, but it's no longer true. If 87 percent of people who graduate from high school all get a university degree, then a university degree is no longer a guarantee of getting a white collar job." For some, K-pop is an alternative way to achieve success.

Indeed, many of these stars do not come from money. "It's like playing the lottery," Saeji described. "You were not smart enough to get into a really good school in Korea, but if you play the lottery of becoming an idol star and you win, then it can become beyond your wildest dreams."

The chances of winning this lottery and landing a successful career are more than slim. "You might train for ten years, debut, and you're famous for three years, and that's it. New ones replace old ones, and people just lose interest," reflected Pang. And even then, becoming an idol does not guarantee wealth.

"Basically when you're a trainee, you incur debt from the training expenses—dance classes, vocal classes—that all costs money," she explained. "The companies are making an investment. They technically will pay you for your classes but will actually charge you later when you're earning an income. And these debts can go up to one million dollars. That's a lot of money, and considering the fact that the companies usually take quite a lot of the profit already, the rest of it goes to paying that debt, and you're left with nothing."

In a country that idolizes youth, idols are debuting younger and younger each year; thus, even successful idols, especially the women, retire at an average age of 25. Comparatively, Victoria's Secret models retire at an average age of 28. With little to no career longevity, trainees and idols leaving the industry have difficulty finding employment after sacrificing years of schoolwork, Pang shared.

For auditionees, like Amy Cao, who auditioned for Sulli's agency, SM Entertainment, when she was 13, it is easy to forget those risks. "I was so determined to pursue that career that I didn't care about the consequences."

After the audition, however, Cao expressed apprehension towards joining SM even if she did get in, due to the dearth of fallback career paths.

The stresses in K-pop, exacerbated by an industry-wide stigma against asking for help, induce high rates of mental health problems. South Korea, which boasts one of the world's highest life expectancies, is equally notorious for its lack of mental health resources: In 2017, it had the highest suicide rate among developed nations.

While this statistic is largely attributed to suicide among Korea's elderly, who suffer from a high poverty rate and lack access to adequate social welfare, suicide rates for young people are also well above the global average. Many point to South Korea's hyper-competitive academic culture and normalization of student stress as primary triggers of mental health disorders for young people. The stigmatization of mental health problems is commonly cited in cases like Sulli's and Hara's.

The last high-profile suicide in K-pop before Sulli's and Hara's was of the popular boy band SHINee's lead singer Jonghyun, who was managed by SM Entertainment and died in 2017. In his suicide note, he wrote, "I am broken from the inside. The depression that gnawed on me slowly has finally engulfed me entirely…. I was so alone…. Please tell me I did a good job." Approximately 40 percent of Korean actors and actresses have reported suicidal thoughts at some point in their careers.

Karen Lu '22, a member of Yale's K-pop and urban dance group, Movement, shared in an interview with *The Politic*: "As consumers of K-pop, we have to be respectful, both online and in real life. Idols are human beings as well."

IN EARLY JANUARY, Amber Liu, Sulli's former bandmate, sat down with *CBS This Morning* for an interview. When

asked about Sulli, she spoke slowly, yet purposefully, as if each word was painful to speak.

"Sulli was like a ball of joy," Liu recollected. "She was always so cute, so rebellious, but you know, she was always like, 'Alright, let's do it.' She was quirky." After a pause, she added, "Sulli was great, and I miss her a lot right now. To be really honest, [I'm] still processing a lot of it."

The progress made by activists pushing for legislative reform—from Sulli's Law to petitions pressuring President Moon to consider harsher punishments for sex offenses—represents hope for the country's deeply-rooted gender inequality. Citizens have also pressured news outlets to completely remove their comment sections, which boast a smattering of hate comments. The internet company Daum Kakao has removed all comments from its entertainment stories, with cyber safety advocates pushing Naver, South Korea's largest search engine, to do the same.

Gibson characterized this new trend in the media market as a "good step," but one that fails to get to the crux of the problem itself. "Why are people holding these women who are celebrities to such a high standard that if they do something slightly different than what people expect, they're receiving all this hatred? I think there has to be a tougher discussion about the roots of that."

It is unclear how we can truly follow that guidance. The reality of deeply embedded prejudice, which extends far beyond the industry, makes change on the everyday scale oftentimes feel fruitless.

"It's about K-pop, but it's not really about K-pop," Gibson reiterated. "It's really frustrating to see Hara and Sulli boiled down to K-pop stars rather than the complex and amazing women that they were. If you talk about this as a K-pop scandal, then nothing changes."

"Why are people holding these women who are celebrities to such a high standard that if they do something slightly different than what people expect, they're receiving all this hatred?"



IN THE MAKING

A legacy of activism inspires climate protests at The Game

PHOTOS BY **ALEXANDER JANKOWSKI, PAUL JOHANSEN**





BY **IAN BERLIN**

ELIZABETH JUVILER '89 first saw the news on Facebook. "Yale and Harvard students delay second half of The Game with divestment protest," she read in the *Yale Daily News*, after a classmate posted the article. "It was just stunning," Juviler told *The Politic*. "It was terrifically effective."

Staring at the screen, Juviler recalled her own fight for divestment while at Yale. From nearly the moment she arrived on campus, she joined protests against investments in the South African apartheid regime, a system of racial segregation that the country's government enforced until the 1990s. As was widely reported at the time, students worked to construct an imitation South African shantytown on the foreboding stone of Beinecke plaza.

In the weeks following 2019's Game, discussion of the halftime protest dominated campus and drew national attention. Within hours, outlets from the *Yale Daily News* to conservative blogs to *The New York Times* (and even the Twitter timelines of several Democratic presidential candidates) buzzed about the event. And yet, the road connecting Juviler to the protesters who stormed the field is long and winding, spanning decades of Yale's history. Only after this journey can we finally answer the essential question: How did the Harvard-Yale protest come to be?

JOSIE INGALL '23 had just arrived on Yale's campus this fall when she joined countless other first-years for the annual extracurricular bazaar in Payne Whitney Gym. Amid seemingly endless rows of tables staffed by enthusiastic upperclassmen vying for her attention, she found herself drawn to one group's poster in particular: "Climate Strike: September 25th." Immediately, Ingall knew she wanted in. Come September, she was.

Ingall is no stranger to climate action. Speaking with *The Politic*, she recounted being surrounded by ongoing climate movements growing up in New York City. "I participated in Fridays for Future protests," which she explained are modeled on the efforts of teen climate activist Greta Thunberg.

So it was a no-brainer for Ingall to get involved at Yale. She recalled, "The only club meeting I went to in the first few weeks was Endowment Justice Coalition [EJC]," one of the organizers of this fall's Climate Strike, where 1,500 students left class to rally on Cross Campus demanding fossil fuel divestment. Ingall quickly fell in love with EJC, especially its commitment to non-hierarchical organizing. "We're able to welcome people with open arms to an organization without an existing power structure," she explained.

"AFTER CRISIS, YOU GATHER YOUR SHIT UP AND YOU ORGANIZE. YOU MAKE IT SO THAT THIS CAN'T HAPPEN AGAIN."

Beyond abstract policy, for Ingall and her fellow coalition members, it's personal. Many have family members in countries that feel the devastating and direct impacts of climate change. "I remember my family sending us pictures of the smoke in the sky when the Amazon fires were at their worst," said Ingall, whose family lives in São Paulo, Brazil. "Those pictures are so deeply terrifying."

She had always been curious about protest. Living near the location of the 1911 Triangle Factory fire inspired her to research the ensuing labor movement. "After crisis...you gather your shit up and you organize. You make it so that this can't happen again," said Ingall.

She also proudly recounted the day of the September strike: "I was in a small seminar, but I was the person responsible for communicating that we were going to walk out. And all of them did." She laughed excitedly over the phone before explaining, "I was one of the people walking around with that group banging pots and pans in the middle of the school day, feeling so at home and scared and also not knowing what the hell was going on."

In the eyes of climate organizers, the strike was a success, yet they immediately began brainstorming how to capitalize on their growing momentum. Martin Man M.Arch '19 told *The Politic* that the 136th Harvard-Yale game in November became an obvious early target, especially because they could partner with students from another school with a massive endowment. "I think I was actually the person who first brought up 'What about the game?'" said Ingall. In all, the protest took about four weeks of dedicated planning.

The organizers split up tasks to get the job done. "My first and most important task was bagel picker-upper," Ingall joked of her game-day responsibility. Primarily, she acted as the group's media liaison along with classmate Jordi Bertrán '23. The event was choreographed into movements of nine separate groups, each with a communications head for coordinating with other groups, a vibes captain for checking in on group members' emotional states, and a police liaison for handling all police interaction.

The morning of November 23rd—critical bagels in tow—all participants gathered in Dwight Chapel to run through the event and ensure everyone knew their assigned roles.

Among those present was Max Teirstein '21, a strategy team member and communications head. Teirstein had been attending weekly meetings to discuss every possible logistic imaginable, including, "what the Yale Bowl looks like, where we would enter from, how we would enter, how we would communicate without [cell] service at the Bowl," he rattled off in an interview with *The Politic*.

Come halftime, following the Yale marching band's performance, the weeks of planning—themselves a culmination of years of activism—came to fruition. Man, Ingall, and Teirstein, in their respective groups, streamed onto the field and took their place at the 50-yard line.



PHOTO BY **ALEXANDER JANKOWSKI**

IN 1966, before any of this began, Jon Gunneman MA '67 PhD '75 followed his friend Charles Powers to an extracurricular study group. "We were looking at the impact of American corporate business in South Africa at the time of apartheid," Gunnemann told *The Politic*. Through his discussions, he "became aware of the ambiguity of investing" in these companies. "What we wanted to do was to get both corporations and the government to think about this," he recounted. "One of the principal things that came to our mind immediately was that the Yale Board of Trustees has a lot of influence."

"The idea was to persuade the Board of Trustees to take a look at what investments in South Africa mean," Gunneman continued. The primary target was obvious: the Board's chairman, J. Irwin Miller '31.

The strategy, too, came to them quickly. "We knew [Miller] read the New Testament in Greek every morning, and we knew he read the *Christian Century*," Gunnemann explained. In January, 1969, he and Powers wrote an article in the magazine calling for universities to consider their investment's social impact.

Gunneman and Powers then wrote a formal proposal to the University, which then-treasurer John Ecklund '38 YLS '41 quickly denied in a lengthy, legalese-filled response.

This setback led Gunnemann and Powers to John Simon, a professor at Yale Law School and president of the Taconic Foundation, which was already practicing an early form of ethical investing. Together, the three met with President Kingman Brewster and the Board to rebut to Ecklund's response.

"As we hoped, John Simon was able to take every single one of [Ecklund's] arguments, one by one, and show that they didn't really work," said Gunnemann, chuckling at the memory.

Gunnemann paused to gather his half-century-old memories before recounting the meeting:

BREWSTER: Well, Irwin, you've been uncommonly quiet—what do you think about this?

MILLER: Well, I sit in a chair every Sunday, the minister says something and people don't have a chance to challenge him on anything. I sometimes think that ministers should be held accountable and responsible for what they say. What these young men are asking us to do is to be accountable for our actions, including our investments. I think that's a good thing.

"That basically broke everything open," Gunneman explained. The trio



PHOTO BY **PAUL JOHANSEN, '88**

received a $10,000 grant to study the topic, organized a year-long research seminar, and then published a final report to the Yale Corporation, before publicly releasing a revised edition. Gunnemman concluded, "*The Ethical Investor* is the result of that."

Nearly 50 years later, *The Ethical Investor* endures as Yale's official guidelines on investing and the definitive source for any consideration of divestment.

JUVILER REMEMBERS the 1995 shantytown proudly. "We had teach-ins there, rallies there, students actually slept on rotation," she shared with *The Politic*. "It was one of the big movements of the moment."

Like Ingall, Juviler cited her family as a significant inspiration for her activism. The granddaughter of socialists and daughter of two constitutional lawyers (and alumni of YLS), she recalled that her parents "went on marches with King and...for women's rights." In addition to her Jewish upbringing, Juviler explained how "the word equality was as close to religion as we got."

Both she and Richard Gervase '89, another then-first-year involved in the protests, credited the shantytown's visibility with attracting both campus-wide and national attention. Gervase said, "There was a physical structure on one of the most prominent places on campus."

The shantytown quickly became a target of Yale Police, who were tasked with removing it despite fierce student resistance. "Many dozens of students were arrested trying to protect it," said Juviler. She also recalled one particularly dramatic sit-in: "It was about 80 of us. We went in the morning, we surrounded the outside of the [investment office], and we sat down. We blocked all the entrances."

That spring, while still a first-year, Juviler was arrested. Along with every other protester, she was detained and punished for the crime of interfering with University property. "That was kind of the point," said Juviler, with a laugh. Ultimately, they were given a lesser sentence of an "internal mark on the record."

With the anti-apartheid divestment protests, all roads seemed to lead to Matthew Countryman '86, now a professor of history and American culture at the University of Michigan. Countryman, a fifth-year senior when Juviler and Gervase were first-years, was a key orchestrator of the shantytown protest. Both explained how much they admired his leadership.

Countryman cited his own inspirations in an interview with *The Politic:* "My parents met in the civil rights movement. My father was white, my mother is African American." He recalled, "We were trying to figure out how to go from a small thing to something that would affect the campus and push the corporation and President Giamatti to change their policy."

The following fall, Yale appointed a new president, Benno C. Schmidt, Jr. '63 YLS '66. To preserve their message in this transition, Juviler and six other students—five of whom had also participated in the previous year's sit in—staged another protest, this time *inside* the investment office.

As Juviler put it, "You can't suspend 80 kids from Yale, but you can suspend five." So with a second mark on her record, she was suspended. I could sense the wry smile as she added that it was "the same day the U.S. Senate approved sanctions against South Africa."

Juviler's usually carefree tone took a marked shift as she remembered how the suspension felt more

"DISRUPTION IS NECESSARY IF YOU WANT PEOPLE TO NOT JUST GO ABOUT THEIR LIVES AS IF THIS IS NORMAL—BECAUSE IT'S NOT NORMAL."

like "expulsion": "I was excommunicated." Following a long pause, she continued: "There was never any response about that when I came back. I was wounded—I felt really burned."

"WE THOUGHT IT was part of the halftime show," said Sam Tuckerman '20, a kicker on the football team, who was warming up on the field when the protest began. "We thought it would be resolved pretty quickly," he shared with *The Politic*. "But the longer it went on the more aggravated I became," especially because the risk of injury increased as players' muscles cooled down with each passing minute. Furthermore, he didn't see the point: "There really is no correlation between climate change and football players."

Following his team's late-game comeback and eventual victory, Tuckerman penned a widely circulated op-ed in the *Yale Daily News*. Concluding that—even if successful—the protest wasn't guaranteed to do much, Tuckerman explained that "the protesters didn't value The Game itself nor the recognition Yale Football has earned over our 147 years of existence, but they opportunistically stole the spotlight that comes as a direct result of both."

Esteban Elizondo '20, in a similar *New York Post* op-ed, compared his peers' actions to a "childish" tantrum. In an email to *The Politic*, he expressed his skepticism about the protesters' disruptive methods: "A good protest should take into account if the tactics and rhetoric are appropriate for the message and the audience you're trying to reach."

It is indeed unclear whether divestment would have any tangible effects. "Even if the entire Ivy League divested," Matthew Zaft, a wealth advisor at Morgan Stanley explained, "it would have a little bit of an impact on the stock, but very, very minute in the grand scheme of things." Unless it created a domino effect among "larger institutions" like Fidelity or Vanguard, divestment would not meaningfully impact fossil fuel companies, he concluded.

A Shell spokesperson echoed this point in an email to *The Politic*. He wrote, "The idea that a University divestment will accelerate our understanding of the most important issues of our time (climate change) or force a new business model is a seductive argument, but it's not reality."

Adele Morris, a senior fellow and



PHOTO BY ALEXANDER JANKOWSKI

policy director for Climate and Energy Economics at The Brookings Institution, amplified the problem in an interview with *The Politic*: "A lot of the protests and activism are... going after divestment because they're trying to change corporate behavior, because corporate behavior isn't being driven as it should be by public policy.... It is a tertiary issue relative to the critical role that public policy has."

As an alternative, Morris advocates for a carbon tax—proportional to CO_2 production—which directly charges companies for their pollution. "The key is to drive investment in low carbon technology and capital," Morris explained.

Indeed, in 2014, Yale itself, through its Corporation Committee on Investor Responsibility, officially acknowledged the "grave threat to human welfare" posed by climate change but concluded that divestment was "neither the right means of addressing this serious threat nor would [it] be effective," preferring instead to pursue change through steps like shareholder action.

President Salovey's statement following the halftime protest adheres to a similar position, explaining that the University does not support divestment, but encourages its investors to consider the environmental impacts of companies in which they invest. Both President Salovey and Karen Peart, the Director of University Media Relations, refused multiple requests to explain what that means in practice, instead referring *The Politic* back to Salovey's statement.

Reinforcing the University's position, Zaft concluded that "for the short term," Yale's divestment from fossil fuel companies would amount to "really nothing at all."

DESPITE THE PHYSICAL centrality of many Yale administrative offices, housed behind Woodbridge Hall's imposing white facade, the offices' internal workings are notoriously secretive, with small insights trickling out in carefully worded statements. Salovey's post-game statement fits the bill exactly. Beyond offering vagaries regarding Yale's actual investment practices, he addressed the manner of protest itself.



PHOTO BY **ALEXANDER JANKOWSKI**

He wrote that "Yale has rules and disciplinary procedures that support free expression while prohibiting significant disruption of campus activities." Here, Salovey seems to reference language from the Report of the Committee on Freedom of Expression at Yale, which stands as the university's official policy on Free Expression, Peaceful Dissent, and Demonstrations.

The report, commonly referred to as the Woodward Report, is named after the committee's chair, C. Vann Woodward, a Pulitzer-winning historian and Sterling Professor of History at Yale from 1961 to 1977. In May 1974, Brewster commissioned Woodward to helm a committee of 13 Yale community members and tasked them with examining the state of free expression on campus.

The report "is one of the great and enduring articulations on any campus of the benefits of freedom of expression and the dangers of suppression of that expression," explained Floyd Abrams YLS '60, a noted First Amendment lawyer at Cahill Gordon & Reindel and founder of YLS's Abrams Institute for Freedom of Expression, in an interview with *The Politic*.

The report articulates both that a) "Every member of the university has an obligation to permit free expression in the university" and that b) "It is a violation of University regulations... to prevent the orderly conduct of a University function or activity."

Despite a "tension" (in Abrams' words) between these two ideals, Peart, speaking for the University and Salovey, declined to clarify where the line is.

Nevertheless, Abrams did not take issue with the two competing

rules: "In general, they can be reconciled. Speech and protest can occur and should be allowed to occur, but they can't interfere with the rights of others."

Importantly, the Constitution only applies to government action, not private institutions like Yale, leaving schools to enforce their own policies. Abrams ruminated, choosing each word deliberately: "Law-breaking is presumptively unacceptable," but that, like during the Civil Rights Movement, "sometimes defiance to law is morally admirable."

THE DIVESTMENT QUESTION comes down to three contentious words: "grave social injury."

This language comes directly from *The Ethical Investor,* which calls for divestment only as a last-ditch effort. Indeed, Simon, Powers, and Gunnemann write, "Divestment, after all other corrective steps have failed, does remind us of the war movies in which the beleaguered infantryman, having exhausted his ammunition, finally hurls his rifle at the advancing hordes." Thus, "social injury"—when companies' actions have an "injurious impact...on consumers, employees, or other persons," as the book says—is the key divestment criterion.

Indeed, both sides cite the same passages of *The Ethical Investor* as proof that they are correct. Students argue there is no harm more grave than the destruction of the planet, while the University claims that the blame is misplaced and that not all options have been exhausted. Given these competing interpretations of the same text, who can know which side is right or what the original authors intended?

"At this point, I would be tending towards yes, we should divest," answered Gunnemann, one of the original authors of *The Ethical Investor.*

Gunneman also pointed to a footnote which offers "Murder, Inc." as a hypothetical example of a socially injurious company. Yale applied this principle when it barred its external investors from investing in assault weapons sellers. Although both Gunnemann and Simon believe tobacco companies fall into the same category as well, Yale allows continued investment in them, instead supporting shareholder resolutions targeting unethical tobacco marketing.

In a follow-up email, Gunnemann considered both sides: 1) Assuming tobacco investments are unethical, "it can be argued that the harm being done to the entire planet and future generations [by fossil fuel industries] is much graver than deaths from tobacco" and 2) Fossil fuel companies do not deserve the sole blame, because "we are all complicit in benefiting from fossil fuels."

Ultimately, Gunnemann decided the fossil fuel investments are unethical regardless. He explained he cannot ignore that "the companies... have long known the harmful benefits of their activities and have hidden the knowledge they had about the harm, lied about it to the public, and actively lobbied government to prevent governmental regulation and/or punishments."

"Hence," wrote Gunnemann, "the statement on p. 93 of The Ethical Investor seems to me to apply directly to them: 'if the harm caused is grave and if there is nothing the university as a shareholder—or anyone else—can do about it in any reasonably near future, then the university should disaffiliate.' This is where I now stand."

AS SOON AS INGALL left the field, the questions began. She quickly spoke to a few student reporters who happened to be at the game before rushing to Blue State Coffee, where she spent the afternoon and evening on the phone with publications from across the country. Later that night, on behalf of Fossil Free Yale and Divest Harvard, she also penned a widely-shared article that ran in *BuzzFeed News.*

Amidst the chaos, Ingall also found a few moments to reflect on the protest's impact and her family in Brazil. "They're very proud," Ingall

beamed. "They understand very intimately the importance of the work being done by young people in America."

Nevertheless, Ingall has already turned her attention to planning and organizing the next climate advocacy event. She explained: "Disruption is necessary if you want people to not just go about their lives as if this is normal—because it's not normal."

Both Morris and Zaft gave reasons for student protesters to feel good about their work. "If Yale is pursuing climate goals at the University level," Morris explained, "maybe it's consistent to say, whether or not our assets would perform better from a market perspective—with or without fossil fuels—maybe this is something we should do to express our distaste for participating in a fossil fuel-reliant future."

In Zaft's eyes, the protest has the potential to effect real change as well. Although "the initial action of someone like Yale doing it would be very little," he explained, "it could potentially be a domino effect that would be very big."

In fact, according to a briefing Zaft forwarded to *The Politic,* investment management firm BlackRock will "exit investments that presented high sustainability-related risk, including thermal coal producers," a move Zaft believes "could actually move the proverbial needle and could be a big domino."

Countryman also praised the protest's student organizers: "I'm very impressed by the planning they did, the support they got from national organizations, and the thoughtfulness with which they engaged the wider student body." He concluded, "Business as usual is not enough." As for Juviler, she sees much of herself in today's protesters. When she saw the Facebook post, "I was proud to be a Yalie," she reflected.

Ever-focused on the future of climate activism at Yale, Ingall argued, "We know that they're listening to us. We're very aware that they're paying attention." Vowing that this is far from the last time we'll hear from her, Ingall spoke with determination: "We're going to keep pushing."



PHOTO BY **MARTIN MAN**



A Different Storm

In a period of relative calm, Iraqis rise up in protest

BY **SHAYAAN SUBZWARI**

HAIDER KARIM HASN'T been home for three months. Spending night and day on the streets of Baghdad, he has been immersed in the recent protests that have swept across Iraq. And since October 1, the Tishreen Revolution—Tishreen meaning October in Arabic—has pulled thousands of other young Iraqis like him into the demonstrations.

Karim hadn't expected this turn of events just four months before the start of the protests, when he moved to an apartment on the outskirts of Baghdad and settled down, marrying a fellow activist. But since Tishreen, he hasn't left the siren call of the protests, despite being faced with a barrage of pleading, tear gas, and bullets.

His friend, Aymen Al-Faisal, told The Politic, "Since the outbreak of protests, [Karim] has been protesting and sleeping in tents and refuses to return to his home and his bride until the demands of the demonstrators are answered.... He is in the

protests and cannot even be contacted."

Karim's story is one of many. With tens of thousands of young Iraqis on the streets and more than 500 civilians killed over the past three months, Iraq and its youth have reached a critical point with the Tishreen Revolution. Amid cries for a complete overhaul of Iraqi politics—in particular, a crackdown on corruption and an elimination of foreign involvement—Iraq's protesters have turned out across the country, grasping at the prospect of change.

SINCE THE U.S. INVASION of Iraq in 2003 and the toppling of Saddam Hussein's leadership, Iraq has plunged into almost continuous conflict. The situation has only worsened with the Syrian Civil War and other challenges to the region's power balances.

Following the deposition of Saddam Hussein, the United States instituted a transitional government in Iraq, assisting the shift in power to the country's Shi'a Muslim religious majority. When elections were held in 2005, Shi'a candidate Nouri al-Maliki assumed the premiership, distressing the Sunni minority population that previously held power under Saddam Hussein.

Tensions between different ethnic and religious communities in Iraq have been exacerbated over the years, with sectarian fighting breaking out between Shi'a, Sunni, and Kurdish groups. While the Sunni minority had primarily governed under Saddam's regime, they were largely excluded under the post-invasion government. Disaffected by this exclusion, Sunnis across Iraq banded together, joining extremist groups like Al-Qaeda in Iraq and leading to the rise of the self-proclaimed Islamic State (IS).

It has only been since the supposed defeat of IS in late 2017 that conflict in Iraq has begun to die down, granting Iraq's citizens newfound freedom to join protests.

In an interview with The Politic, Baghdad-based reporter Ali Nabhan explained, "There [has been] a potential for Iraqis to protest since 2011…but by 2014, the priority was the war against Daesh [IS]. After the defeat of Daesh, Iraqis got a big hope that things would finally change. Iraqis got united and sectarian tensions have kind of vanished."

After years of warfare, the timing was finally right for protests in Iraq.

BUT THE PROTESTS have been anything but straightforward. Indeed, the demonstrations are best considered in the plural, with no singular aim for any protester and factional movements on different sides.

Perhaps the biggest issue on the minds of Iraqis, and especially the Iraqi youth, is corruption. Baghdad-based political analyst Dr. Muhammad Al-Waeli explained in an interview with The Politic, "Many of the protesters [are] very young. These people are going to need jobs, and this wasn't available after ISIS was defeated—because of corruption."

Karim, too, faces this issue. After his father died from a car bomb explosion in 2007, Karim was left with the task of supporting his family. He hoped to find a stable career after completing a degree in political science but instead had to settle for a job at a local money exchange. Working multiple jobs to make ends meet, he eventually pulled enough together to purchase the apartment he hasn't seen in months.

Karim's employment problem is shared by many other young Iraqis, who overwhelmingly see governmental corruption as the source of the issue. Despite being equipped with years of education and college degrees, Iraq's educated youth still cannot find jobs that maintain a decent standard of living.

With the aim of uprooting and removing the corrupt elite that has ruled the country since 2003, Iraqi protesters have demanded reforms to incorporate newer and younger figures into politics and bring an end to persisting corruption.

Pressured by weeks of protests, the resignation of Prime Minister

"It doesn't matter if you are Sunni or Shi'a or Kurdish or Christian, you are suffering as an Iraqi citizen from the fact that the people at the top are stealing and stealing and stealing."

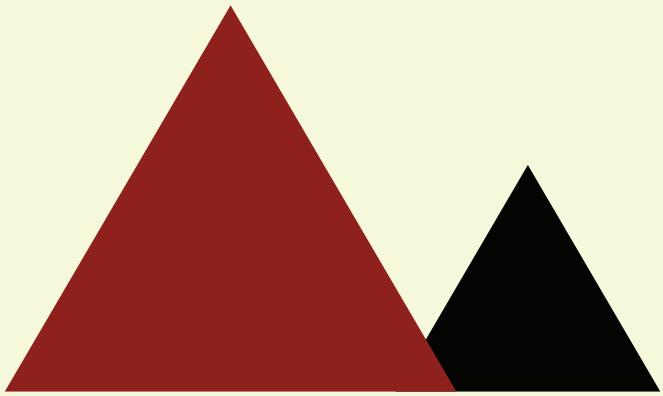
Adel Abdul-Mahdi on December 1 was hailed as a necessary first step towards dismantling the corrupt elite by many demonstrators across Iraq.

Furthermore, when an Iran-backed bloc in Parliament nominated veteran politician Asaad Al-Eidani as Mahdi's replacement, Iraq's President, Barham Salih, threatened to resign in a statement of dissent, signaling the influence of the demonstrations. "[President Salih] didn't want to be remembered as the one who gave the power to a political nominee of the parties. The protesters are trying to pick up an independent, non-partisan prime minister," explained Nabhan.

In addition to the resignation of the Prime Minister, pressure from the protests has resulted in the passage of crucial new election laws in Parliament. Iraqis can now vote for individual politicians rather than from party lists, allowing independents to compete for seats in Parliament. Moreover, with the passage of a bill reforming the High Electoral Commission, Iraqis now have hope for an independent and non-partisan electoral committee.

However, some still harbor concerns about the reforms. "Despite the approval of the election law and the commission law, I believe the government and Parliament are not serious about meeting the demands of legitimate protesters. Nothing will change because of the Iranian pressure on political parties," said Al-Faisal.

It's this Iranian pressure that so many young protesters like Al-Faisal's friend, Haider Karim, have taken issue with.



"Since 2011, Iraqi protests have been silenced time and time again under the pretense of war and the fight against ISIL."

"THE PROTEST MOVEMENT aims to save Iraq from external domination…. Regarding the Iranian influence, this influence came as a result of the weaknesses of the Iraqi state…and [these] young Iraqis are angry at the controlling of factions outside the authority of the state," said Al-Faisal, speaking of Karim and the protesters.

On November 27, Iraqi protesters in Najaf stormed the Iranian Consulate, burning down the building and demanding an end to Iranian influence in Iraq. Not only did this action break from the peaceful majority of protests, it also brought front and center the issue of Iranian interference. Anti-Iranian protests are part and parcel of the anti-corruption movement Karim has joined.

Joseph Sassoon, Al-Sabah Chair in Politics and Political Economy of the Arab World at Georgetown University, explained in an interview with The Politic, "I would say the vast majority of the protests have been more anti-Iranian [than anti-American]. Iran's control of the politics is really, truly very profound…. The Prime Minister and all these guys can't do a thing without approval from Iran."

Since 2014, Iran's presence in Iraq has been a fixture of the political system. Through funding militias such as Kata'ib Hezbollah in the fight against IS and forming select alliances in Parliament, Iran managed to claim its position in Iraq and hasn't left.

And so as young Iraqis take to the streets, calls for an end to Iranian interference have proliferated.

A separate anti-American movement, however, has also found prominence. On December 31, just over a month after the burning of the Iranian consulate, an Iraqi militia and its supporters raided the United States Embassy in Baghdad. The attack followed an earlier American airstrike on Kata'ib

Hezbollah, which had killed more than two dozen people.

"With regard to the American resentment, partly it's political—whipped by Iran—but partly, there is this sense that the U.S., because of the invasion, has really brought Iraq into total, utter chaos," explained Sassoon.

According to Sassoon, the distinction is that anti-American sentiment is largely harbored by those civilians older than the average protester, and not necessarily those out on the streets: "The people who are in their 40s and 50s and remember Saddam are having nostalgia for those days because there was security. Yes, there was corruption, but no one stole $400 million."

So as young Iraqis like Haider Karim join the demonstrations, anti-Iranian sentiment has continued to take the front stage. Meanwhile, Iranian-supported militias such as Kata'ib Hezbollah hold the brunt of the responsibility for committing anti-American actions.

With the assassination of Iranian General and Quds Force Commander Qassem Suleimani in Baghdad on January 3, Iraq seems to serve as a proxy battleground between the United States and Iran as threats of attacks unfurl. Two days later, the Iraqi Parliament demanded the expulsion of all foreign troops from the country as anti-foreign sentiment continues to rise.

AS FOREIGN RESENTMENT heightens within the Iraq protests, entrenched resentments across sectarian lines have taken a back seat. Rather than the flags of sectarian groups or militias, the protests have mostly been characterized by a nationalist energy with Iraqi flags and emblems. Faced with the common enemy of foreign interference, people across different sects of Iraq have seemingly banded together.

"The protests are mostly about corruption and not political. And since it is not political, it has not become sectarian. It doesn't matter if you are Sunni or Shi'a or Kurdish or Christian, you are suffering as an Iraqi citizen from the fact that the people at the top are stealing and stealing and stealing," explained Sassoon.

"Faced with the common enemy of foreign interference, people across different sects of Iraq have seemingly banded together."

Though the non-sectarian nature of these protests has presented a huge advantage, the movement has experienced its fair share of challenges. Faced with an intensive crackdown by the Iraqi Armed Forces and the predominantly Shi'a Popular Mobilization Units, more than 500 civilians have been killed and 20,000 injured over the span of two months.

Some civilians, too, oppose the protests due to fear that foreign powers might be pulling the strings. Al-Waeli explained that, "When there are protests you see bots on social media spreading and retweeting hashtags, and after investigations, it's found that these are often troll farms located in Saudi Arabia and the Gulf. So people are dubious about these movements and what they can be derailed to, as we have the example of the Arab Spring."

This resistance seemingly stems from fears of Iraq spiraling into another brutal conflict promoted by foreign powers, similar to those of failed regime changes in the Arab Spring.

AS THE UNITED STATES and Iran send threats to one another, the Islamic State has begun to pose a new danger in Iraq. On January 5, the international coalition fighting IS—including the U.S. and the U.K.—announced that it would suspend operations against the terrorist group due to concerns about a potential U.S.-Iran conflict.

Yet, this announcement comes just two weeks after Lahur Talabany, an Iraqi Kurdish commander, claimed that IS is "getting stronger again in Iraq."

Stuck between IS and a U.S.-Iran dispute, the future of the protest movement in Iraq doesn't look bright. Since 2011, Iraqi protests have been silenced time and time again under the pretense of war and the fight against IS.

But until full-scale conflict remains simply a possibility and not a certainty, the Iraqi youth and Haider Karim still find themselves on the streets.

"The young people who went out in Iraq finally found themselves able to make some change, and although it is not what they have been looking for, there was some response. Those young people believe they can make a change. This is a huge shift in the mentality of the Iraqi people," said Nabhan.

The Iraqi protesters have stood through years of war, corruption, terrorism, and foreign interference. After repeated silencing, the protests have finally claimed their moment and taken up the push for change.

Al-Waeli shared, "Change happens when you continuously push in a very well-thought manner and with a plan and long-term thinking. That's when change happens—that's when reform happens."

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PERSONAL ESSAY

COLORS OF CITIZENSHIP

Minority groups fight for a more inclusive India

BY **RAM VISHWANATHAN**

"RIDICULOUS! TELL ME, RAM—do you really think these students even know what they are protesting about?" my *Thatha*, grandfather in Tamil, complained, frowning as he peered into the morning newspaper.

Thatha's question pulled me from my winter holiday torpor. I had arrived ready for rest at my grandparents' house in Coimbatore, a city in southern India. Although Coimbatore has a population of almost two million, it is known in India as a "Tier-II" city, its pace of life considerably tamer than some of India's chaotic, sprawling megacities. As a native of Bangalore, one of those irrepressibly effervescent metropolises, I often spend my visits to Coimbatore in a lethargic stupor, the city's year-round sultry climate and languid passage of time sapping my will to do much more than nap, spend hours on marathon online chess sessions, and feast on my grandparents' cooking.

I had braced for this question with a combination of dread and eagerness. Like many Indian students, I returned for winter break engrossed by political events back home. I joined Twitter and stayed up late reading news. I wrote and signed petitions and exhorted my parents and friends to do the same. When my parents remained too disengaged for my liking, I retorted over text: "I hope we have an answer two decades later when my kids ask us what we were doing when this happened. If you're satisfied with yours, then sure, rest easy."

In the case of *Thatha*—and indeed, much of his generation—I expected to be confronted with opposition more than apathy. I had carefully prepared my arguments, and began to methodically explain why I found recent changes in India's laws downright dangerous. But before I could get very far, my grandfather interrupted me. He opened his phone, pointing to

a message he had been forwarded on WhatsApp that was both misleading and plainly inaccurate. Our discussion would soon be derailed by an inability to agree on basic facts and figures—facts as simple as what the new law actually stated.

THE CAUSE OF THIS TURMOIL was the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA), passed on December 11, 2019 by India's lower house of parliament. The ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) argues that the act will provide refuge to persecuted minorities among India's neighbors. But a look at its actual language reveals that the CAA contains neither the word "persecuted" nor "minority." The CAA restricts its ambit to individuals from six religious communities—Hindus, Sikhs, Christians, Buddhists, Jains, and Zoroastrians—who can demonstrate that they entered the country before December 31, 2014 from one of three countries: Afghanistan, Bangladesh, and Pakistan. The law will no longer consider them illegal immigrants; instead, they will be offered an expedited path to Indian citizenship.

Muslims are the obvious exclusion from the law, the first in India's history to tie citizenship to religion. The law also makes several other seemingly arbitrary distinctions, including the exclusion of neighboring countries like Sri Lanka, China, and Myanmar. That these countries are home to persecuted minorities–many of them Muslim–reveals the act's pernicious contradictions.

To be fully understood, the CAA must be read together with plans for a nationwide National Registry of Citizens (NRC) announced last year. The NRC shifts the burden of establishing citizenship onto the individual by demanding documents of proof from every citizen, a particularly difficult task for India's marginalized populations. The CAA serves as a safety net for the NRC, ensuring only India's Muslims can be rendered stateless.

India's Home Minister, Amit Shah, admitted as much last April to a room of reporters: "First the CAB [Citizenship Amendment Bill] will come. All refugees will get citizenship. Then NRC will come. This is why refugees should not worry, but infiltrators should. Understand the chronology."

In the BJP's dictionary, the word "infiltrator" implies "Muslim." In an election rally, Shah explicitly connected the two, proclaiming, "We will ensure implementation of NRC in the entire country. We will remove every single infiltrator from the country, except Buddha [*sic*], Hindus, and Sikhs." Much of his party's rhetoric has borrowed from—and indeed, gone beyond—nativist right-wing rhetoric across the globe. In a chilling speech delivered last year, Shah even termed infiltrators "termites."

These laws have triggered a firestorm across the globe. While the government has shrugged off international criticism, it has responded to domestic dissent with brute force, especially against Muslims and pro-

testing students at India's most prestigious universities. Prime Minister Modi himself delivered a speech proclaiming that those inciting violence can be "identified by their clothes"—referencing the traditional attire of Muslim men and women. Yogi Adityanath, the Chief Minister of Uttar Pradesh, India's most populous state, also promised "revenge" against dissenters. Uttar Pradesh has seen some of the worst police violence, with 23 civilians killed.

But protesters have soldiered on. To India's Muslims, recent government actions resemble a threat to their very right to have rights, the latest step in a long history of marginalization that has been central to the BJP's rise to power.

IN 1987, when India's current prime minister, Narendra Modi, joined the BJP, the party held only two seats in India's parliament. Modi had long been a member of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), a right-wing Hindu nationalist volunteer organization. The RSS and its various affiliates—together known as the Sangh Parivar—subscribe to a political philosophy often called *Hindutva*, which asserts that the Indian nation is co-constitutive with Hinduism. For much of the 20th century, the Sangh Parivar remained a fringe group in Indian politics, which were dominated by the Congress Party in the decades before and after Indian independence in 1947. The Congress Party has typically endorsed a secular democratic platform, beliefs enshrined in India's 1950 Constitution.

The BJP rose to national prominence in the 1990s through a carefully orchestrated, highly publicized campaign to build a temple to the Hindu deity Ram in Ayodhya, his purported place of birth. The BJP and its affiliates alleged that the Babri Masjid, a 16th-century mosque in the city, had been built on the remains of a destroyed Hindu shrine. In 1992, the mosque was demolished by a Hindu mob consisting of Sangh Parivar members, which sparked a wave of communal violence across India. Riding the wave of religious polarization that followed, the BJP became the largest party in parliament in 1996. The site of the destroyed Babri Masjid remained an important tenet of the Sangh Parivar's politics, whose members continued to make pilgrimage to Ayodhya to advocate for the construction of a Hindu temple on the site.

In February 2002, one such set of Sangh Parivar members was returning from Ayodhya when their train compartment caught fire. Fifty-eight people perished in the inferno. Modi, then just five months into his tenure as Chief Minister of Gujarat, allowed the Sangh Parivar to publicly parade the victims' corpses in the state's largest city, Ahmedabad. As enraged Hindu mobs–many of them coordinated by members of the RSS–rampaged across the city, promising revenge against the Muslim community, the state's law enforcement was conspicuously absent.

Numerous human rights groups alleged that members of the police in-

stead took part in the violence against Muslims. Evidence also suggests the riots were planned and executed with the help of voter rolls that informed the mob where to find Muslim homes. In the aftermath, Modi and his government embarked on a Hindu pride rally across the state, featuring incendiary speeches and thinly disguised support for the perpetrators of violence.

The events of 2002 established Modi's credentials among the BJP's hardliners. But India's minorities, a fifth of the country's 1.3 billion people, usually vote the other way. Although the 2002 events in Gujarat allowed Modi to consolidate his control over the state, Modi lost face outside his bastion. He was banned from entering the U.S. or the U.K., and the BJP lost control of Parliament in the 2004 elections.

Modi and the BJP realized that an image makeover was required. In the next decade, Modi toned down his communal rhetoric in public, and made efforts behind the scenes to cover up any evidence of his involvement in supporting or failing to prevent the riots. As a child, I never learned of the events in Gujarat in 2002.

With Modi as the face of their campaign, the BJP came to power in 2014 promising inclusive development and clean governance. But they also made sure to keep their *Hindutva* base within reach, maintaining a marked silence following a series of mob lynchings.

Seeking a second term in 2019, Modi found himself overseeing an economy suffering from one of India's worst recessions. Facing an upcoming election, he raised his nationalist rhetoric to a fever pitch. Two months before the election, an attack on a military convoy that killed 40 soldiers gave Modi an opportunity to control the narrative. Supported by India's biggest businesses, an army of social media trolls, and dozens of TV news channels that have increasingly stoked Islamophobic fears, Modi projected himself as a strongman leader that would teach Pakistan—and India's Muslims—their place. The BJP won another emphatic victory, with millions of Indians expressing their preference for a "strong" leader at the center. *Thatha* was one of them.

FIVE DAYS AFTER that aborted conversation with *Thatha*, I returned home to Bangalore. We had not broached the conversation again during the rest of my time in Coimbatore.

Politics was clearly in the air in Bangalore. I was immediately struck by the pervasiveness of the color saffron, a symbol that has come to represent *Hindutva* politics, assertively displayed on flags in temples, public spaces, and on the sides of hundreds of taxis and rickshaws. However, saffron was not the only color on display.

The day after I returned to Bangalore, I joined a protest at Town Hall, a prominent landmark in the city center. Saffron had been replaced by the tricolor of orange, white, and green–India's national flag. Volunteers paced throughout the crowd, handing out



PHOTO BY RAM VISHWANATHAN

Protesters gather on the steps of Bangalore's Town Hall, January 3rd.

bananas, water bottles, and copies of the preamble to the Constitution of India, while students, activists, and religious leaders took turns addressing the crowd. Some spoke in English, some in Hindi-Urdu, and others in Kannada. Some sang poetry; others used more earthen language. Their message, however, was remarkably similar. Each speaker grounded their language in the vocabulary of an inclusive India, pointing to the Constitution as the symbol of that ideal. Between every speaker, the crowd spontaneously broke into impassioned chants of "Long Live India," "We Want Freedom," and "We are One."

I HAVE FOND MEMORIES of HMT Ground, a large sporting area in northern Bangalore. It was the site of many of my high school cricket matches, and always provides a welcome visual respite from the city's concrete sprawl. But on this warm day in early January, just a day after the Town Hall protest, the Ground was unrecognizable. Almost 3,000 people had gathered on what would otherwise be a sleepy Saturday afternoon, but the sheer size of the crowd was almost lost beneath a sea of Indian flags.

I had dragged a reluctant friend along, in part because of an earlier conversation in which she revealed her belief that Muslims were religiously dogmatic in their faith and out of touch with modernity. The Ground is located in the middle of a large Muslim colony, and the crowd was made up of a sea of bearded men in flowing white kurtas and veiled women in black niqabs. As is the case in most Indian cities, Muslims in Bangalore are often prevented from co-inhabiting residential spaces with upper-caste Hindus, and thus congregate together in less affluent neighborhoods. The image of the burqa-clad woman and the bearded man still viscerally unsettle many Hindus today. When my friend saw the colors of the crowd, she grew hesitant and called for an Uber.

The opposition has been wary of how the right uses such visuals to frame resistance in purely religious terms. Shashi Tharoor, an intellectual heavyweight in the Congress Party, embroiled himself in controversy when he tweeted a video of Muslim protesters chanting the Kalimah, one of the basic expressions of Islamic faith, at a protest. Tharoor wrote, "Our fight against *Hindutva* extremism should give no comfort to Islamist extremism either." Many on the left lambasted Tharoor for what they argued was a less overt but similarly dangerous form of majoritarianism. Tharoor defended himself by saying he was seeking to "broadbase the cause," writing that "for most of us, the struggle is about India, not about Islam."

As a Muslim cleric came up

to speak on the stage, my thoughts turned to these debates.

"*Bismillah Ar-Rahman Ar-Raheem,*" began the imam. I expected the next line of the Quran to follow.

I was in for a surprise.

"This is my country!" he continued, switching to an eloquent Urdu. "I was born from this dirt, and I will die here too. Who are you, Mr. Modi, to tell me I don't belong here?" The crowd roared, and a thousand Indian flags soared in the brilliant blue sky.

"Long live India! Long live India!" boomed the crowd.

"Our constitution does not invoke the name of Allah, or *Bhagwan*, or God. It begins with 'We the People.' This country of ours is not founded on the basis of a single religion. We are all Indians. I may pray in my mosque and you in your temple or church, but we are all equal before the law."

My friend's Uber arrived, and she left in a hurry. But later that day, I received a text from her.

"I honestly felt really bad today. The little I heard…it just moved me."

India's Muslims have always had their loyalty to the nation questioned. They have been termed "anti-national." They have been accused of harboring sympathies for Pakistan, sponsoring terrorism, and having too many children. They have faced violence, marginalization and apathy from institutions meant to protect them. For years, they have borne this discrimination quietly.

The past month has opened the floodgates. With their very citizenship in question, Muslims have responded by taking to the streets peacefully while wearing their religious identity proudly. The image of a woman in a black niqab waving the Indian flag challenges the rhetoric of those in power, and it has become ubiquitous on India's streets today.

And Muslims are not alone. Many of their neighbors have joined them in protest, forming coalitions across class, caste, religion, and gender lines. This diverse group of protesters has proudly reclaimed national symbols previously monopolized by the right, imbuing them with new meaning through their acts of defiance. Long considered dead relics of ideals like secularism and democracy imposed by a distant elite, these symbols have taken new meaning as the language of the streets—and of the idea of an India home to all.

BACK IN COIMBATORE, *Thatha* no longer shares the right-wing political messages he would often forward to our family WhatsApp group. Instead, I am greeted every other morning with videos of physics-defying stunts or gifs of cat bloopers. Perhaps he is wary of upsetting me. Perhaps the BJP's recent rhetoric has gone too far for him. Perhaps, as for many like him, recent events have become another fleeting historical interlude.



Citizens attend a protest on the grounds of Hindustan Machine Tools, January 4th

A Conversation with Alain Bertaud

on scooters, shrinking cities, and the future of urban development

BY **EUNICE PARK**

ALAIN BERTAUD is a Senior Research Scholar at the NYU Marron Institute of Urban Management and recently authored the book *Order Without Design: How Markets Shape Cities*. Bertaud previously held the position of principal urban planner at the World Bank and has worked as a resident urban planner in a number of cities. His research aims to bridge the gap between operational urban planning and urban economics, primarily focusing on the intersection of markets, regulations, and transport infrastructure.

HOW DID YOU BECOME INTERESTED IN URBAN PLANNING AND HOW HAS THE FIELD CHANGED SINCE THEN?

I have always been working on cities which were developing fast, and it was important to [combat] the pressure of population growth [by] develop[ing] more cities. However, now there are more cities with stagnant or decreasing populations. These shrinking cities are a new problem that we don't know how to deal with. I first saw this change 12 years ago in Russia. I was asked to review the government development plan of Saint Petersburg and Moscow, but on the side, they asked me, "Could you help us on something else too? We want to close 60 cities." I told them that I had never faced this problem before.

HOW CAN HOUSING AFFORDABILITY IN ONE CITY AFFECT NEIGHBORING REGIONS? ARE THERE DIFFERENT METHODS TO HAVE A UNIFIED SOLUTION?

You find the problem of affordability practically everywhere in the world, [in part due to] a shift in urban planning starting in the '60s. Planners have begun to design cities [according to] a preconceived idea of what the city should be like. Due to this change, many regulations were imposed, all of which are very drastic in terms of what you can do on a lot. The city is designed too far in advance for the planners to know what is affordable. For instance, there has been a failure to anticipate the shrinking of household size. There is now a need for smaller apartments or smaller houses, but regulations have not adapted to that.

WHAT DO YOU THINK ARE THE MOST EXCITING DEVELOPMENTS IN URBAN PLANNING TODAY?

The proliferation of urban transport, starting with shared scooters and rapid trains, which are becoming cheaper. I think that this is the first time in 100 years that we have a change in the nature of urban transport, which will change how land is used. I'm pretty sure it will have a positive impact.

DO YOU EVER WORRY ABOUT THE SHIFT FROM GOVERNMENT TO PRIVATE PROVISION OF THESE RESOURCES?

I think that this is a positive sign. The role of government is to regulate. The role of the city is not to say, "We want to ban scooters," but it is to say, "Scooters are providing an interesting means of transportation, so we are going to provide some areas where people can park their scooters." This is the regulation the city should do.

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